

The iPhone Is Hackable!

Researchers at Independent Security Evaluators, a company involved in testing clients' computer security, informed of an Apple iPhone vulnerability which was detected by hacking the Wi-Fi connection and also by browsing to a Web site containing malicious code.



Xbox Warranty Woes

19 July, Microsoft said it expects to spend more than \$1 billion (Rs 4,000 crore) to repair widespread hardware problems in its Xbox 360 video game console. A large number of them have broken down of late after firmware upgrades by consumers.



Enter



Anand Virani,
Associate Vice President, Geodesic

Mundu Radio is a mobile-based application that allows you to connect to any Internet-based radio station you'd want to. We caught up with Anand Virani, associate vice president of Geodesic, the developers behind Mundu Radio, for a quick salvo of questions...

What sets Mundu Radio apart from other players like the Nokia Internet Radio Client?

Virani: Most internet players have a fixed playlist, or cannot search for third-party Internet radio stations. Mundu Radio is one of the only applications that allow users to add their own stations to the list. In future editions of the application, a search feature labelled "discover" will be added; this will allow members to search for stations based on genre, time period, and more. Mundu Radio is also the only cross-platform player—it works on Series 60 Symbian as well as Java-based phones.

How much will Mundu Radio cost once out of beta?

Virani: We are in the process of rolling out a commercial version of Mundu Radio. Since the cost of bandwidth in India is high and unlimited data plans are expensive, we are looking at providing the service at a very attractive rate. The pricing model could be based on a "one time downloading fee," though that will be decided later.

Will you bring in your own local content as well?

Virani: India is a key market for us and local content is very popular. There are about 50 Internet radio stations we have found that air local content. If you access the "India" genre in the playlist, you will find most of the popular stations there. We are constantly being approached by Internet radio stations, and are looking to partner with as many of them as possible.

OLPC NEWS AGAIN

Intel Steps In, Unexpectedly

A brief recap: under the OLPC (one laptop per child) project, a laptop loaded with XO software, costing \$100, would be given to every child in participating developing countries to aid learning. This was the brainchild of Nicholas Negroponte, founder of the well-known MIT Media Lab.

It didn't remain a Negroponte affair. It became a low-cost-PC-for-the-third-world thing, even if no-one actually used the word "third world." Intel hopped on the proverbial bandwagon of low-cost PCs, unveiling their Classmate PC, a laptop for children—but more expensive, and with more features.

The scene became almost ugly: Intel chairman Craig Barrett referred to Negroponte's XO Laptop as "a \$100 gadget." A miffed Negroponte ranted: "Intel should be ashamed of itself. It's just—it's just shameful," in an interview with the BBC News Web site. Mr Gates himself later pointed to the lacking design of the XO laptop, its lack of a hard drive, and its small screen.

Negroponte went on to say Intel's problem was that an AMD-designed processor was being used in his XO laptop. The competition and differences were increasing.

Brace yourselves: Intel, out of the blue, joined hands with the OLPC project. Everyone was taken by surprise, taken aback, even.

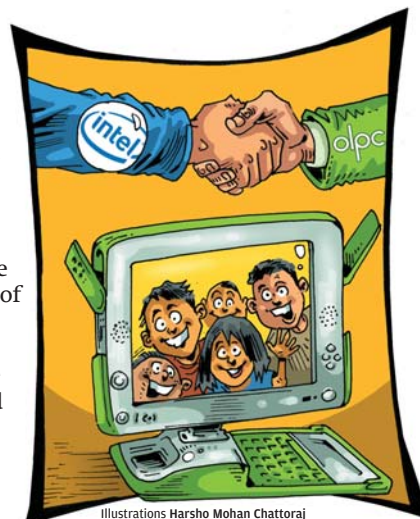
A delighted Negroponte said, "Intel joins the OLPC board as a world leader in technology, helping reach the world's children. Collaboration with Intel means that the maximum number of laptops will reach children."

Software for the Classmate PC would run on the XO laptop. Future XO models could have Intel chips, speculation went. The question that now arises is about the role of AMD, who have been silent about the entire issue. Whose processor would the XO laptop carry?

That hardware decision will be taken by the OLPC Foundation. "Eventually, different PCs with different hardware and software would be offered by OLPC," Walter Bender, head of software development at OLPC, informed the BBC News Web site.

Then again, the OLPC project needs to tackle several issues that surfaced in the course of their pilot test. The most recent is that of setting up filters in regards access to explicit content; Nigerian students have used the laptop to surf porn.

This project has been ongoing for the past five years. Pilot studies are still



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

on. Issues such as explicit-content filters, the cost of a proprietary OS, eco-friendly hardware, longer battery life, and storage in terms of a hard drive need to be addressed by the OLPC project. However, Negroponte's bottom-line is: "This is an education project, not a laptop project."

The icing on the now-musty cake is that the project still faces criticism; some say children in developing countries need food, clothing, and shelter—not laptops. The latest updates say the XO Laptop is now in production and might be released late December 2007.

Still, it's not now a one-man show, a one-project drama. Intel's stepping in will make a difference: the chip giant isn't in it for charity. There will be